

Automate Your Development Environment **with Vagrant**

Get introduced to Vagrant—a tool for managing virtual machines. By taking care of these machines, Vagrant allows developers, operations engineers and designers to get on with their core work.



Vagrant is a tool that helps to manage virtual environments, which means it works with virtual machines (VMs). It provides a simple and easy-to-use command line client for managing these environments, and an interpreter for the text-based definitions of what each environment looks like, called Vagrantfiles. Vagrant is open source, which means that anyone can download it, modify it, and share it freely.

Many virtual machine hypervisors provide their own command line interfaces and, technically, the provisioning of virtual machines through these programs can be done directly or through shell scripts. What Vagrant provides, by adding a layer, is simplicity across multiple systems and a more consistent approach, which could theoretically be used with any virtual environment running on top of any other system.

By providing a common text-based format to work with virtual machines, the environment can be defined in code, making it easy to back up, modify, share and manage with revision control systems like Git. It also means that, rather than sharing a whole virtual machine image, which could be many GBs, every time a change is made to the configuration,

a simple text file of just a few kBs can be shared instead.

Why and how Vagrant helps you

It's worth mentioning that Vagrant makes things really easy. I mean, there's no tangle of wires or the need to use Vim, apart from the loads of annoying command line stuff. Vagrant makes it easy to run a development environment. While, at its core, Vagrant provides a rather simple function, it may be useful to a wide range of people working on different kinds of tasks.

For developers, Vagrant makes it easy to create a local environment that mimics the environment upon which your code will eventually be deployed. You can make sure you have the same libraries, dependencies and processes installed, as well as the same operating system and version, and many other details, without having to sacrifice the way your local machine is set up, and without the lag or cost of creating an external development environment and connecting to it.

For operations engineers, Vagrant gives a disposable environment and consistent workflow for developing and testing infrastructure management scripts. You can quickly